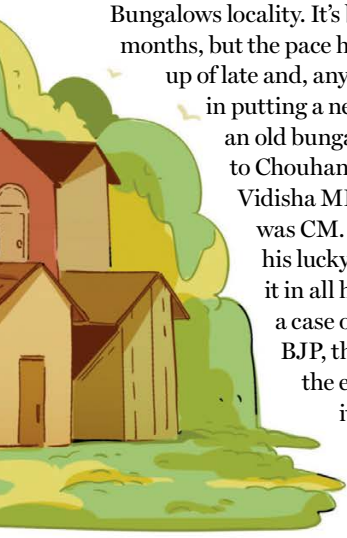
Is Shivraj Singh Chouhan already contemplating a quiet, retired life looking at the grass grow on a colonial bungalow's lawn? Well, a naughty Congress would have you believe so, implying that Madhya Pradesh's longest-serving CM has read what they happily claim is the painting...sorry, writing on the wall. Proof? A major facelift being imparted to a nice pad in Bhopal's 74 Bungalows locality. It's been going on for a few months, but the pace has apparently picked up of late and, anyway, what's the harm in putting a new coat of rumour on an old bungalow? It was allocated to Chouhan back when he was the Vidisha MP and Digvijaya Singh was CM. Perhaps considering it his lucky mascot, he retained it in all his years as CM. In a case of bad timing for the BJP, the renovation caught the eye of the Congress and it lost no time dubbing it 'Chouhan's retirement abode', given the higher-than-normal bustle around the place. The bungalow, B-8, stands allotted to Chouhan as the MLA from Budhni, while he puts up at the humble casita designated for the CM at Shyamla Hills. A few months ago, the adjacent B-9 bungalow, which was lying vacant, has been lassoed into the B-8 campus. If he wins, that will be just three houses in all. Even if not, he should be able to cope. ■







Who Two?

Don't know Rajasthan Congress beyond Ashok Gehlot and Sachin Pilot? Well, here are two worthies worth your attention, if only for the frequency with which you can hear them being dissed in Narendra Modi–Amit Shah speeches. Urban development minister Shanti Dhariwal, who's just turned 80, is the man behind the magniloquent (and "corruption-riddled") make-over of his constituency, Kota. He also courted fame when, on the subject of rape, he offered the opinion that "Rajasthan is a state of men". Subsequent apologies made no difference, as they should not. Rajasthan Tourism Development Corporation bossman Dharmendra Rathore, meanwhile, is famed for his diligence. He used to painstakingly update his diary with daily jottings—but alas, his aide-memoire was made public by a dissident minister. The BJP calls it the Red Diary, rife with alleged references to sleazy money deals. It also accorded due space to a remark attributed to CM Gehlot's son Vaibhav, predicting a massive defeat for papa as early as 2020. The duo were in the high command's firing line because they were part of the dramatic revolt last year when party bosses were trying to persuade Gehlot to contest for AICC president and make way for Sachin Pilot. Dhariwal has survived the purge with a last-minute ticket. Rathore is riding into the sunset like a valiant Rajput, at least for now. ■

SHE'S IN THE LOBBY



Vasundhara Raje may be off the roster as the BJP's main face but she's the only local eminence there for other candidates, even if only those on her side are being graced with a rally (she's doing 60) in her whirlwind state tour. All other names being propped up as alternate chief ministerial faces are tied down to their own constituency. Like leader of opposition Rajendra Rathore. He has good reasons to stick to the bleak Shekhawati beauty of Taranagar. Despite seeking refuge here from neighbouring Churu, Rathore may still be driving on loose sand. PM Narendra Modi, who has taken it upon himself to be the sole BJP mascot, surprised everyone when he dropped by on November 19—for one of his 26 rallies (as against 12 in 2018). With Rahul Gandhi too gracing Taranagar earlier, that only deepened the sense of doom. Raje's counterpart in the Congress is, of course, CM Ashok Gehlot. Like Raje from Jhalrapatan, he too is confident enough in his Sardarpura seat to be able to be mostly campaigning outside. ■

Rahul Noronha, Rohit Parihar and Amarnath K. Menon